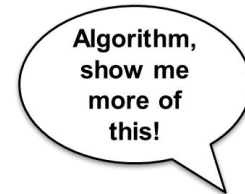


Exploring the cosy media realities of personalised social media apps: the case of TikTok

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Comfort, coziness, and media

- Comfort and coziness are popular media qualities, increasingly promoted by online platforms to address audience desires for soothing content and “comfort creators” (YouTube 2022).
- Cozy and comfortable are often treated as synonyms herein. However, dictionaries imply a hierarchy of the terms, with coziness referring to a particular state of comfort.
- **Guiding question: how can we develop comfort and coziness as distinct analytical concepts to better grasp the well-being effects of personalized media?**

Synonyms and antonyms of comfortable in English

comfortable

f x

Thesaurus > comfortable > comfortable

These are words and phrases related to **comfortable**. Click on any word or phrase to go to its thesaurus page. Or, [go to the definition of comfortable](#).

COMFORTABLE

• After a long jou

Synonyms an

comfy

Informal

There are two b

cosy

UK

The living room

snug

She longed to b
cottage.

coziness noun

/'kəʊzɪnəs/

/'kəʊzɪnəs/

(North American English)

(British English **cosiness**)

[uncountable]

1 ☐ a feeling of being warm, comfortable and safe

SYNONYM **snuggles**

• the warmth and coziness of the kitchen

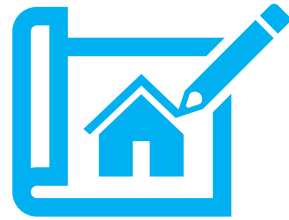
TikTok as a case

- Central platform in the global social media landscape (Su 2023), appealing through **personalized “For You” page** and its algorithmic curation of short-video content.
- **Safe and escapist online space** (Barta and Andalibi 2021), engaged with as personal retreat from the demands of everyday life (e.g., Kang and Lou 2022, Siles and Meléndez-Moran 2021, Şot 2023).
- Re-analysis and **deductive engagement with 18 months of digital ethnographic fieldwork**, combining immersive platform and interviews, repertoire mappings, participant observation with 30 UK-based young adults.



Comfort: a state of worldly orderedness and normalcy

- A foundational discussion of **mediated comfort** is offered by Silverstone (1994), drawing on Giddens' (1991) notion of **ontological security** to describe how media support the conduct of everyday life.
- **Comfort emerges from routine and habitual conduct, creating a “protective cocoon”** (Giddens 1991) that shields people from existential worries and supports the ongoing writing of biographic self-identity.
- Building on Douglas (1966), comfort can further be understood as the outcome of **ritual purification**, the work of managing “dirt”, matter out of order, that would otherwise introduce ambiguity and discomfort into the flow of daily life.



TikTok and everyday comfort



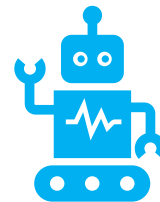
As a technology, TikTok is a ready-to-hand tool that is supporting spatio-temporal ordering of daily life.

Mona: “I go on it to relax, chill, and just have a laugh to spend something like 40 minutes on [TikTok] before I maybe make dinner.”



As a text, TikTok provides access to a familiar symbolic environment of “relatable” content.

Judith: being on TikTok “is just like seeing what your friends are up to if your friends were all kind of cool and you didn't have any obligation to them.”



Negative cases reveal comfort is algorithmically mediated, when the “TikTok algorithm” fails to purify the feed, app becomes a source of discomfort.

Will: repeatedly exposed to content of “happy couples” that turned TikTok from comfort into a source of discomfort during breakup.

Coziness: an aesthetically intensified state of comfort

- **Coziness differentiates itself from comfort through an aesthetic and material intensification**, drawing on Bachelard's (1969) poetics of intimate space, where warmth and shelter emerge through embodied engagement with material surroundings.
- Where comfort relies on the metaphor of writing the biographic self at ease, coziness can be understood as a matter of listening, an attuned, sensorial perception of being in touch with the world (Gumbrecht 2012).
- Work on cozy media further shows that **coziness is a felt quality** (Bódi 2024), reliant on specific ways of **engaging with media that afford temporary retreat** into aesthetically pleasing, slower atmospheres (Andiloro 2024).



TikTok and cozy feelings



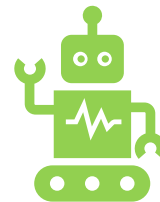
Aesthetic immersion on TikTok enables heightened feelings of comfort through resonance with soothing, romanticized content.

Belna: described going on TikTok to see cottagecore videos, content of just “nice people doing nice things” living in the countryside.



Imaginative closeness to significant others emerges in videos sparking memories and intimate reflections, content sharing practices.

Joyce: described seeing videos that related to conversations with friends or childhood experiences shared with her sisters.



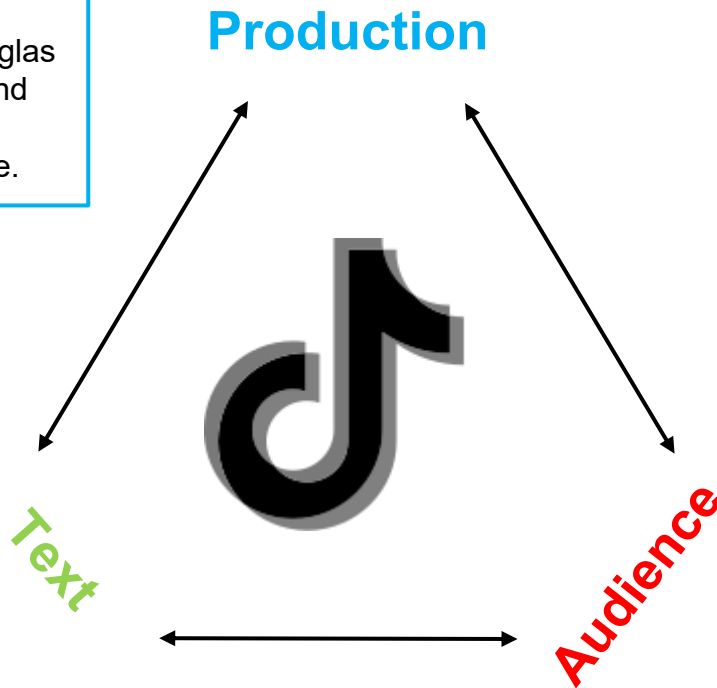
Negative cases reveal that coziness collapses when algorithms feel too close to home, producing exposure rather than shelter.

Jade: a video touching on migration and identity from her ethnic background felt like “this is way too close”.

Enacting cozy comforts on TikTok

“TikTok algorithm” performs the ongoing work of purification (Douglas 1966), removing “dirty” content and scaling down the platform to a familiar, intimate symbolic surface.

TikTok’s authentic and relatable aesthetic (Barta and Andalibi 2021) supports general comfort, while concentrated pockets of particular genres give rise to more focused cozy experiences.



People's ability to navigate these algorithmic curation becomes decisive (Siles et al. 2025), shaping whether TikTok is experience as a space of comfort, coziness, or neither.

Triangulation analysis based on Kellner's (2011) dimensions.

Conclusions

- **Comfort and coziness are related but analytically distinct**, with the former denoting a general state of worldly orderedness, the latter an aesthetically intensified modulation thereof. Metaphorically, comfort is about easing the process of writing the biographic self, whereas coziness is about listening to and being in touch with the world.
- **Cozy media experiences are not given but emerge from situated entanglements** between production, text, and audience practice (Kellner 2011). TikTok becomes a cozy space only through particular configurations and enactments (Siles 2023) of all these three elements – and collapse if any does not align with the others.
- **Future directions:** questions of media literacy, the construction of cozy spaces across integrated polymedia environments (Madianou and Miller 2013) and the rise of **non-conventional cozy media** (Boudreau et al. 2025) where coziness emerges through audience and community appropriation of commercial media landscapes.

Thanks!

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